

Why Does Materialism Lose Out to Religion the World Over?

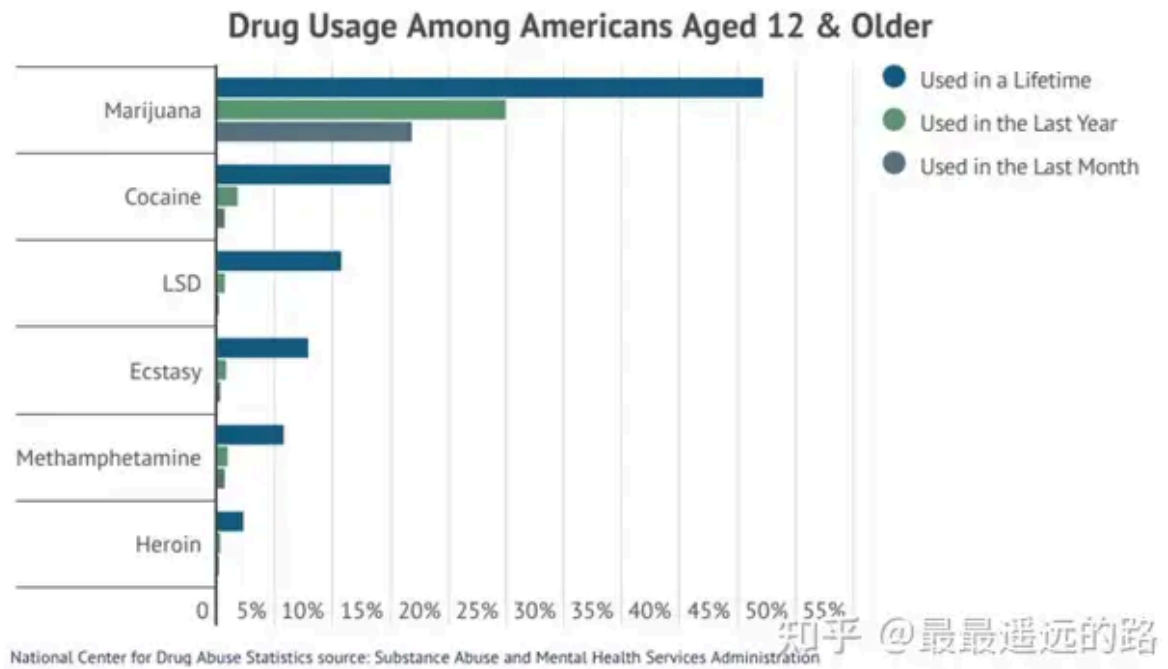
Zhihu

Materialism fails to compete with religion because, whether under feudal society or under capitalist society, the life of the masses is truly too bitter. A person must pass through a great many gates before life can be lived out in relative happiness. From entering school, to finding a job, to courtship and marriage, to raising children — everything is shot through with enormous uncertainty, like bombs and blades flying at you in a video game, where a single cut can kill you or drain most of your health. What is still more disheartening is that, very often, individual effort counts for little while all manner of factors beyond one's own control play the decisive role. Not only the labouring classes, but even members of the ruling classes are frequently toyed with by fate.

When a man loses his job and, in consequence, his marriage collapses, how is he to face his own life and this world? When a student fails the college entrance examination and so loses all chance of a university place, how is he to regard the cruel arrangement of fate? In an age of pervasive anxiety, how does materialism help you find calm? A materialism of that kind does exist, but understanding it is extremely difficult: it demands not only passing through the fantasies driven by one's unconscious desires, but also seeing through the whole structure of society and the principles by which it works.

Religion, by contrast, offers a relatively simple order. When misfortune strikes you, "God has his plan" is far simpler than figuring out the social causes behind the misfortune, or understanding the unconscious desires that drive one to a nervous breakdown. Belief is an important way of preventing mental collapse. This is why Marx wrote that religion "is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world, just as it is the spirit of a spiritless situation. It is the opium of the people." Nothing could be said more pointedly.

In fact, as religion began to ebb and atheism arose, the religion once regarded as spiritual opium was replaced by the real opium. As we all know, in the United States the abuse of various drugs and psychiatric medications has become a grave social problem^[1].



Drug Abuse Statistics

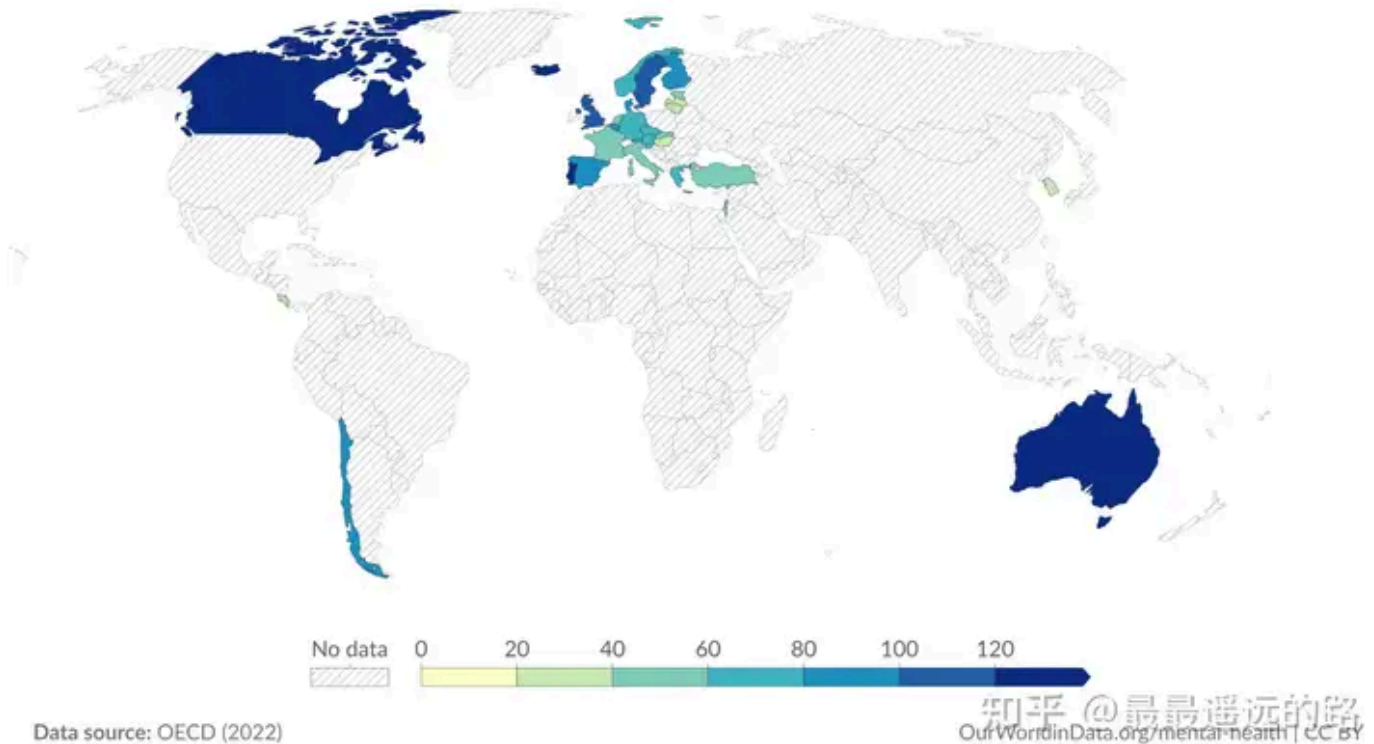
This is not confined to the United States; it runs through the whole developed world^[2]. The use of antidepressant psychiatric medication has become a widespread social phenomenon.

Antidepressant drug consumption per 1,000 people, 2021

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Daily intake of antidepressants per 1,000 people, calculated as the 'defined daily dose'.

This enables us to compare overall levels of drug consumption, accounting for the fact that different antidepressants have different recommended dosages.



This flood of medication parallels the ebbing of religion and the rise of atheism^[3]. Chile in Latin America, for instance, also suffers from a flood of medication, while the share of its population without religion is comparable to Europe's — an outlier by Latin American standards.

Share of the population who are religious, 2020

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Estimates are based on how people describe their own religious identity. This self-identification is taken regardless of their practices or beliefs. Estimates include people who are affiliated with any religion.



Data source: Pew Research Center (2025)

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Share of religious believers

Among the countries of the Confucian cultural sphere, the proportion of atheists is virtually the highest on earth. As the social transformation of these countries completes itself, the hold of traditional Confucian moral precepts has begun to weaken (their grip was never as firm as that of a genuine religion), and it is quite possible that in the future the fashion of material opium will spread there. Vigilance is called for.

Notes

[1] Drug Abuse Statistics: Among Americans aged 12 years and older, 47.7 million were current illegal drug users (used within the last 30 days) as of 2023.

中文原文：《Drug Abuse Statistics》Among Americans aged 12 years and older, 47.7 million were current illegal drug users (used within the last 30 days) as of 2023.

<https://drugabusestatistics.org/>

[2] Antidepressant drug consumption per 1,000 people, 2021.

中文原文：Antidepressant drug consumption per 1,000 people, 2021

<https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/antidepressants-per-capita>

[3] Religious composition (share of believers).

中文原文：Religious composition

https://ourworldindata.org/grapher/religious-composition?religion=any_religion&indicator=share

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